



Our lake house. Sometimes real estate is not an investment, it's a money pit. Consider renting—it's often a better option.

(Kevin O'Leary)

2. **Swimming pools.** So you won't get a lake house, but you'll install an in-ground swimming pool so the kids can hang out in the backyard for the summer. Installation can cost anywhere from \$25,000 to \$50,000. That doesn't include the new fence with the kidproof lock and the new patio furniture. And don't count on the kids to care for and maintain the pool. They'll talk the big talk and make all sorts of promises, but when it comes down to cleaning and vacuuming the pool, it's going to be either you or someone you hire. Add the cost of chemicals, filters, and a higher electrical bill and you're looking at paying about 10 percent of the pool's initial costs, per season. That's the estimate a reputable pool company will give you. Installing a \$30,000 pool? You're paying \$3,000 a season to keep it clean and safe. But the biggest concern is resale value on your house. Always remember that your idea of summer fun is a prospective buyer's idea of a big headache.